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For the President
26 July 2026



US Halts Strikes on Iran After Two Weeks as Both Sides Probe a Diplomatic Off-Ramp

We assess that the absence of a US strike on Iran over the past 24 hours—the first such lull since the air campaign resumed on 7 July—reflects a tactical pause rather than a strategic decision to de-escalate, shaped by target attrition and back-channel signaling as much as by any breakthrough. President Trump says publicly that Washington and Tehran "remain in talks" and that Iran is "getting more serious," even as he keeps US forces "locked and loaded"; an Iranian official has dismissed that characterization. We judge both sides are testing an exit while preserving the option to resume.

- The lull follows 13 consecutive nights of US strikes. Press reporting indicates nearly 100 US personnel have suffered mostly minor injuries in Iranian counterfire since 7 July, and at least four service members have been killed.
- We assess Tehran retains the capacity to resume attacks on Gulf shipping and US regional positions; its declared "closure" of the Strait of Hormuz remains in effect, and no ceasefire framework is yet on the table.
- Israeli Prime Minister Netanyahu is scheduled to meet the President at the White House on Tuesday. We expect the visit to shape whether Washington resumes strikes or presses for a pause, and to test any daylight between US and Israeli war aims.

For Washington, the central question is whether a 24-hour pause can be converted into a durable ceasefire before an incident on Gulf waters forces re-escalation. We assess the risk of renewed fighting over the coming days remains high, and a single tanker or casualty event could collapse the lull.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from CIA, DIA, NSA, INR, and open sources.

For the President
26 July 2026



Saudi-Houthi Exchange Widens the Red Sea Front, Holding Oil Near \$100

We assess the Saudi-Houthi exchange of the past 24 hours marks a meaningful widening of the Iran-centered conflict into a second maritime theater, sustaining a war-risk premium that has held Brent crude near \$100 a barrel. Early Saturday the Saudi-led coalition struck the Houthi-held port of Hodeidah after the group attacked Saudi-linked tankers in the Red Sea; the Houthis said they answered with missiles and drones against the kingdom.

- The Houthis declared a maritime "embargo" on Saudi Arabia earlier in the week and have struck at least two Saudi-linked tankers—the NCC Masa and the Encelia—threatening a second chokepoint at Bab el-Mandeb alongside the effectively closed Strait of Hormuz.
- We judge the combination of Hormuz disruption and rising Red Sea risk is the primary driver of crude's roughly 14% weekly gain; forecasters have raised year-end Brent estimates toward the \$100 mark.
- Overhead imagery shows fresh damage at Hodeidah consistent with the reported coalition strikes.

For Washington, a sustained two-front maritime war raises the odds of expanded US Navy involvement in Red Sea escort and keeps energy-driven inflation risk on the table into the fall. We expect continued tit-for-tat strikes unless the broader Iran track cools.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from DIA, NGA, NSA, Treasury OIA, and open sources.

For the President
26 July 2026



Ukraine Presses Deep Strikes Into Russia as Moscow Renews Attacks on Kyiv

We assess Ukraine is sustaining a deliberate long-range campaign against Russian energy and logistics nodes even as Moscow keeps striking Ukrainian cities, with both sides trading blows over the past 24 hours and neither showing appetite for talks. Ukraine's General Staff reports overnight strikes on an oil refinery at Tyumen, a logistics facility at Yekaterinburg, and a fuel depot at Rostov-on-Don, among other targets deep inside Russia.

- Russian forces launched a renewed ballistic attack on Kyiv on 26 July, striking a residential building. It followed a 24 July missile strike on a defense-industry exhibition in Kyiv region that killed at least 10—including an employee of a Polish defense firm—prompting a regional day of mourning on 25 July.
- The death of a Polish defense-company worker adds a NATO-member dimension; we assess it will sharpen European pressure to accelerate air-defense deliveries.
- We judge Ukraine's demonstrated reach into the Urals and the Caspian signals a maturing deep-strike capability that Moscow cannot fully defend against.

For Washington, the tempo underscores Kyiv's continued dependence on US- and European-supplied interceptors even as its own strike reach grows. We expect Ukraine to press hard for additional air defense in the near term.

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For the President
26 July 2026



Mediterranean Heat and Wildfires Displace More Than 300,000 in France and Spain

We assess the wildfire emergency across southwestern Europe—now displacing more than 300,000 people in France and Spain—is straining two key NATO allies' domestic emergency capacity at the peak of a record Mediterranean heat wave, with fresh evacuation orders issued into 26 July. At least one person has died.

- Spanish authorities describe a wildfire near Madrid as "beyond the capacity of firefighters to contain," with more than 20 towns evacuated across Madrid and Ávila. Spain has deployed thousands of personnel and drawn EU assistance from Greece, Italy, and Portugal.
- France, battling fires in its southwest, is bracing for its fourth heat wave of the summer beginning midweek, raising the risk of further ignitions.
- We assess the disaster carries limited direct US security exposure but real allied-bandwidth and economic costs, and again casts climate-driven instability as a recurring strain on European partners.

EU civil-protection mechanisms are once more the first line of response. We expect the fire risk to persist through the incoming heat wave, with tourism and agricultural losses mounting across the western Mediterranean.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from NGA, INR, and open sources.

For the President
26 July 2026



Vehicle Attack at Berlin Pride Kills One; Motive Not Yet Established

We assess the 25 July vehicle attack at Berlin's Pride festivities—one person killed and at least 16 injured when a van drove into crowds near the Tiergarten—underscores the persistent threat of low-sophistication attacks against soft targets in Western Europe, though German authorities have not yet established a motive. Police identified a 21-year-old suspect they say was previously known to them.

- Press reporting cites police describing the suspect as known "in Islamic circles," but no group has claimed the attack and investigators have not publicly designated it terrorism. We caution against firm attribution pending the German investigation.
- The vehicle-ramming method and the choice of an LGBTQ gathering fit a recurring pattern of attacks on crowded events; we assess copycat risk is elevated across European summer festivals in the near term.

For the homeland, we judge the tactic is readily transferable to US venues and warrants continued vigilance around large public gatherings. DHS and FBI routinely track such incidents abroad for domestic read-across.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from FBI, DHS/I&A, INR, and open sources.

For the President
26 July 2026



Repeated China-Philippines Clashes Raise Escalation Risk in the South China Sea

We assess a run of confrontations between Chinese and Philippine forces—three in the past week, including a 24 July Chinese water-cannon incident against a Philippine vessel carrying journalists—marks a sharper, more physical phase of the maritime dispute that raises the risk of a lethal miscalculation. A US–Japan–Philippines maritime exercise ran through 25 July.

- Earlier in the week a Philippine sailor was injured about the head in a boat-to-boat clash near Second Thomas Shoal; Washington publicly condemned Beijing's "dangerous and aggressive" actions, and the two capitals have traded blame.
- We assess Beijing is deliberately testing Manila and its allies below the threshold of armed conflict; the trilateral drills signal allied resolve but do not address the underlying friction.

For Washington, the key risk is that a Philippine death could implicate the US–Philippines Mutual Defense Treaty. We expect continued gray-zone pressure rather than open conflict, with alliance credibility the stake Beijing is probing.

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Notes

- **Sudan:** Rapid Support Forces drone strikes on El Obeid, the North Kordofan capital, have continued at a near-daily pace, and UN humanitarian officials this week warned of a looming catastrophe as the paramilitary tightens a siege on roughly half a million people. We assess the encirclement echoes the pattern that preceded mass atrocities at El Fasher and judge a ground assault a realistic near-term possibility absent outside pressure.
- **South Korea:** Seoul is investigating a breach of the Korea National Diplomatic Academy disclosed this week, in which intruders exploited a zero-day flaw to sit undetected for months and exposed data on up to 10,000 current and former diplomats. Investigators have not attributed the intrusion but are weighing a possible North Korea link; we assess the target set is consistent with DPRK collection priorities against South Korean and allied diplomacy.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from NSA, INR, CIA, and open sources.